



**Power-hitter:** Michelsen's power was on full display when he blasted 52 winners against fellow American Tommy Paul in their Delray Beach Open clash. AFP

it."

On his remarkable breakthrough, Leavitt said, "He went from an ordinary junior to a pro within a year, which probably hasn't happened in 20 years."

At the US Open last September, the 127th-ranked Michelsen ambushed Spanish veteran and former No. 17 Albert Ramos-Vinolas, 6-4, 6-3, 6-4. Four months later, he proved it was no fluke when he stunned No. 23 Jiri Lehecka 4-6, 6-3, 6-4, 6-4 in the Australian Open second round. "He believed this was all going to happen the way it's happened, and we, as parents, didn't quite see that," said his father. Added his mother, "I think he has a great belief in himself."

Michelsen's nip-and-tuck 5-7, 6-4, 7-6 (4) Delray Beach Open loss recently to fellow American Tommy Paul showcased his power, blasting

52 winners. But another attribute caught the eye of *Tennis Channel* analyst Paul Annacone, who coached superstars Federer and Sampras. "His tennis IQ is off the charts. You rarely see him select the wrong shot. He's a fun player to watch."

Similarly impressed with Michelsen's precocious game, Paul said, "He's a great player, he makes everything super tricky. It's hard to break his serve, hard to beat him backhand to backhand. He's definitely improving every week, and he'll be on Tour for a long time."

His meteoric rise and the accolades continued the following week at the ATP 250 event in Los Cabos, Mexico.

Michelsen notched his first top 10

victory, overpowering No. 9 Alex de Minaur 6-4, 6-1 with big serves, accurate backhands, and adroit volleys. "The all-court tennis he produced was mesmerizing and magnificent," said *Tennis Channel* analyst Rob Koenig.

A red flag appeared, however, at the ATP Next Gen Finals last November. In four tests measuring the athleticism of the elite eight players, he finished eighth in the 10-meter sprint, reaction test, and agility drill. He was seventh in the vertical jump. Pro tennis requires more athleticism than ever. For Michelsen to crack the top 20 in the world rankings, he'll have to improve in all these areas, especially his sprint speed.



**Impressed with his performance at the Australian Open 2022 junior event, Djokovic invited Jakub Mensik to train with him for a few days**